

News Article

Title: New Child Care Subsidy Begins in January 2026 to Support Australian Families

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The Australian government introduced a new “three-day guarantee” childcare subsidy on 5 January 2026, ensuring that families across the country receive at least three days of subsidised early childhood education each week, aiming to improve affordability and increase access to early learning programs.

From January 2026, the federal government’s “3 Day Guarantee” ensures that all Child Care Subsidy-eligible families can access at least 72 hours of subsidised early childhood education and care per fortnight, equivalent to three days per week, and as new data shows more than 341,000 children were enrolled in preschool programs nationwide in 2024 according to the Australian Bureau of Statistics.

The Department of Education said the legislation aims to expand access to early childhood education and support Australian families facing rising childcare costs. The government stated the reform would ensure that “every child has the opportunity to benefit from early learning.”

Data from the Australian Bureau of Statistics shows that 96 percent of children were enrolled in preschool programs for at least 15 hours per week, and the data also found that about 78 percent of children enrolled in preschool programs paid \$4 or less per hour after subsidies in 2024. However, some private kindergarten institutions will have even higher prices. ZiDie

Wang, who worked as a tutor in a private kindergarten named The Green Elephant, she point out that this policy has indeed benefited preschool children's education and Australian families. Wang said: "Some private kindergartens may charge between \$20,000 and \$30,000 per year. However, according to our regulations, the specific fees of our school, I'm sorry, I cannot disclose."

Wang said "One of the reasons why this Child Care Subsidy is so important is that preschool education is very crucial. It is of great significance for students to go to kindergarten or other early childhood education organization before they go to the primary school. Although children aged 3 or 4 may seem very young, their various abilities, such as cognitive abilities and writing skills, seem to surpass those of most people and they can learn a lot. For example, when children engage in play-based learning activities such as building blocks, storytelling, or exploring nature, they are actually developing important thinking and communication skills. "

A scholar SiYi Liu, who study Early childhood education for children in Victoria University, also emphasized the significance of this policy. She stated that early childhood education is a crucial period in one's life, in the meantime it also holds a great importance for society. Liu said: "Early childhood education is often described as a critical stage because many fundamental skills are developed during this period. Research suggests that about 90% of brain development occurs before the age of five." She empathized that early experiences play a significant role in shaping children's cognitive, psychological, emotional, and social development. Positive learning experiences during early childhood can support lifelong learning, while limited opportunities may create developmental gaps.

Over the past decade, early childhood education has become an increasing policy focus in Australia as governments attempt to address both educational inequality and workforce participation. Analysts note that access to affordable childcare can play an important economic role by allowing more parents to return to work. At the same time, researchers argue that consistent participation in early learning programs can help reduce developmental gaps before children enter primary school. Compared with a decade ago, preschool enrolment rates have remained high across Australia, reflecting growing recognition of the long-term social and economic benefits of early childhood education. The federal government's new subsidy reform is therefore seen as part of a broader national effort to strengthen early learning access.

In the announcement, the Department of Education said the reform would help ensure that "every child can benefit from early learning opportunities, regardless of their family's work circumstances." Over the past decade, preschool participation in Australia has steadily expanded as governments increased investment in early childhood education. meanwhile, both interviewees said that early childhood education is extremely important, and that this policy will benefit children, families, community, and the country as a whole, and they all believe that this policy will continue to ensure quality early childhood education.

1. Main Media/Press Release Sources:

- <https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/people/education/preschool-education/latest-release>

2. Other Media/Press Release Sources and Data Sources:

- <https://www.education.gov.au/early-childhood/announcements/3day-guarantee-legislation-introduced>
- <https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/child-care-subsidy-changes?context=41186>

